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UP IN ARMS L-R, Union home minister Amit Shah, Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi, West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee, Tamil Nadu CM M.K. Stalin

tion in 1976, the Emergency year that saw her National Population Policy. The point was to reassure the South, which had curbed its population growth more effectively than the North. Since seats follow population, a fresh Census would have hardened an already uncomfortable North-South gap into a structural one.

The 84th amendment in 2001, under A.B. Vajpayee, which effectively extended the delimitation time-frame by another 30 years, acted on the same principle: states that flattened their fertility curves would not pay for it in Parliament. The need for the incentive was real—and still is. The Hindi belt's total fertility rate remains well above the southern average—Bihar at 3.0 and UP at 2.4, against 1.8 in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, and 1.7 in Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh. The 84th Amendment altered Article 82 and froze seat shares derived from the 1971 figures until the first Census after 2026 was published. That Census after 2026 would have been 2031. But India missed conducting the exercise in 2021 because of the COVID-19 pandemic, which is why it has rolled into 2026. Being a digital exercise, the numbers are expected next year, setting the stage for delimitation. But since the process typically takes two to three years to be completed, it leaves a slim window before the 2029 Lok Sabha election.

Another anxiety stems from the fact that the Indian scheme places too much discretion in the hands of a Delimitation Commission that, according to its critics, is "bipartisan in appearance and unilateral in function". The 2026 Bill stipulated that the commission would be headed by a sitting or retired Supreme

CAN DELIMITATION USE THE REVENUE SHARING FORMULA?

With some MPs asking for weightage to be given to GDP performance in delimitation, here's how the 16th Finance Commission reworks the formula

42.5%
INCOME DISTANCE*
The biggest factor. Poorer states get more funds to ensure fairness

17.5%
POPULATION
Based on 2011 Census, to reflect how many people need services

10%
CONTRIBUTION TO GDP
A new factor. States contributing more to the economy get rewarded

10%
AREA
Larger states get more due to higher costs of governance

10%
FOREST & ECOLOGY
States with more forest cover, including open forests, are rewarded

10%
DEMOGRAPHIC PERFORMANCE
States that controlled population growth get an advantage

**Income distance is the gap between a state's per capita GSDP and that of the state with the highest per capita GSDP*